

The Aftermath



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It's always the minute that follows the news of a natural disaster that's the worst. You try to reach out to your loved ones, fail, attempt to cajole yourself into believing that everything's alright, fail, rinse, repeat. You feel dehydrated, your throat clenches up and you can almost imagine the walls of your esophagus clench hard in an attempt to squeeze out some moisture. You can't think beyond the next few seconds, your thoughts forming a perfect circuit, fears and hopes feeding each other in a grotesque display of symbiosis in the absence of real information.

And then, your call goes through, you hear their voices on the other end and realise they're fine. They're okay, they're all okay, the mantra is on loop in your head.

On the 25th April of this year, an earthquake measuring 7.8 on the Richter scale hit Nepal minutes before the mid-day sun was at its apex. The earthquake was so strong that it was felt in nearby countries like Bhutan, Tibet and Pakistan and in Indian states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Delhi and Sikkim. My parents and my sister live in Sikkim while a large part of my extended family lives in Kathmandu which is the reason why that Saturday morning I was dripping anxiety when the news of the earthquake's lethality floated through social media.

Today, when I look back on that day, I wonder how I would have reacted if I existed within a total feedback vacuum, if I had no ability to access tools like Twitter, Facebook, Google News, Viber and WhatsApp. I'm not someone who panics easily but when I do, I tend to spiral downwards quickly and I realise that if it wasn't for those tools, that Saturday would have been worse, if that's even possible, for me and many others like me.

Let me extrapolate by talking more about that morning. When I felt the earth shake, my first thought wasn't that the situation was serious; after all, I had experienced smaller quakes in Delhi before. I jumped on to Twitter and the magnitude of what had just happened slowly crept over me as tweets popped into view on my feed. When the first BBC tweet that formalised the gravity of the quake appeared, I was already trying to call my folks in Sikkim. Understandably, the network

was jammed, but I did manage to get through and, to my relief, find out that they were fine. Once I was done, I headed to Facebook to browse the timelines of my relatives and friends from Nepal. I could see that a couple of them had posted updates, even though their phones had been unresponsive, which meant that the quake and the resulting tide of concern had pretty much knocked out the country's voice network but the data network was still limping along. Viber and WhatsApp came into play after that. With the help of Viber (and unsuccessful attempts using Facebook Messenger and WhatsApp's calling services), I was slowly able to get in touch with some of my relatives and find out that they were fine.

Facebook and WhatsApp came in handy when one of my aunts in Delhi reached out to me saying that she was unable to get in touch with her family in Kathmandu. Over the span of about an hour, I was able to get news of them and relay the information to my aunt.

By the time evening came, I had successfully managed to talk to, or at least hear from, most of my relatives, thanks to tools that hadn't existed a mere seven years ago. As the weeks rolled by, more news of the devastation in Nepal flowed through, peppered by signs of hope and courage that the world saw on its combined newsfeeds, timelines and inboxes. And somehow it felt like, against all odds, the people in the country where I've spent some of the most joyous moments of my life, would endure and pick themselves up.

So, what would that day have been like if I had been unable to hear from or talk to those in Nepal? I try not to think too long about the answer to that question.

If you want to help those affected by the earthquake in Nepal, head to <http://digit.in/nepal-quake-help> to get a list of charities you can donate to. 

Let me know your thoughts on this column at: @postwar | nikhil@digit.in